

Chapter 17: The Cost of Staying

Jenny didn't say anything after that.

Not because she had nothing to say.

But because everything she thought of sounded dangerous.

So she stood up.

Turned away.

And went back to work.

But this time, it didn't feel like escape.

It felt like delay.

Austin stayed.

Of course he did.

And Jenny hated how normal it was starting to feel.

Like his presence belonged in her day.

Like table seven was no longer just a table.

It was... him.

Hours passed.

Lunch faded into afternoon.

Afternoon into evening.

The restaurant slowly emptied.

And still, he didn't leave.

Jenny noticed him less loudly now.

More subtly.

The way he read.

The way he paused sometimes and looked toward the kitchen.

The way he didn't check his phone as often as before.

Like something outside this place mattered less.

That thought unsettled her.

"Jenny," Bao whispered as they cleaned tables.

"He's still here."

"I know."

"He's never stayed this late."

"I noticed."

Bao smirked.

"You're getting used to him."

Jenny shot him a look.

"I'm not."

"Sure."

"I'm not."

Bao raised both hands.

"Okay, okay. Relax."

Jenny didn't relax.

She couldn't.

Because every minute he stayed...

It felt like something tightening.

Not around her.

Around both of them.

When the last customers left, Madam Chen locked the front door early.

Only staff remained.

The kitchen was quieter now.

Lights dimmer.

Air softer.

Austin still sat at table seven.

Jenny finally walked over.

"You're done," she said.

"Yes."

"Then leave."

A pause.

Then—

"I will."

Jenny frowned.

"You always say that and then don't move."

Austin looked up at her.

Not amused today.

Just steady.

"I'm waiting."

"For what?"

"For you to stop pretending this is nothing."

That made her still.

The words weren't loud.

But they hit exactly where she was weakest.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"This *is* nothing."

Austin nodded slightly.

"No."

That single word again.

Calm.

Certain.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"You're making this harder than it needs to be."

"I'm not making it anything," he said quietly. "I'm just not leaving it alone anymore."

Silence.

The restaurant felt empty in a different way now.

Not quiet.

Heavy.

Jenny looked at him.

Really looked.

The arrogant businessman was still there.

But softened at the edges.

Worn down by something she didn't fully understand.

Or maybe...

By her.

That thought made her stomach tighten.

"You can't stay like this," she said.

"I can."

"For how long?"

A pause.

Then honestly—

"I don't know."

That answer should have reassured her.

It didn't.

Jenny stepped back slightly.

"This is going to get messy."

Austin stood slowly.

"I think it already is."

Jenny shook her head.

"No. You don't understand what messy means here."

Austin stepped closer.

Not too close.

But close enough that she had to look up slightly.

"Then show me," he said.

Jenny froze.

"That's not how this works."

"Then how does it work?"

She hesitated.

Because she didn't have a clean answer.

Not one she liked.

So she said the only truth she could manage.

"It doesn't."

A long silence.

Austin studied her.

Then said softly,

"Then why haven't you told me to stop?"

That question hit harder than anything else.

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it again.

Because the answer scared her.

Finally, she whispered,

"Because you don't listen."

A faint pause.

Then—

"No," he said quietly. "I listen to you."

That made her look up sharply.

Austin continued.

"You just don't believe it yet."

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

She hated how calm he sounded.

Like he had already decided something she hadn't agreed to.

Like he had already stayed in a place she hadn't allowed.

She stepped back again.

"Go home, Austin."

He didn't move immediately.

Then—

"I am."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not what I meant."

Austin looked at her one last time.

And for the first time, there was something different in his eyes.

Not uncertainty.

Not confusion.

But resolve.

"I know," he said.

Then he turned.

And walked out.

No hesitation.

No argument.

Just leaving.

Jenny stood still long after the door closed.

Because something about the way he said it...

Made her feel like he wasn't stepping away from her.

He was stepping into something that now included her whether she agreed or not.

And for the first time...

Jenny wasn't sure she was still in control of where this was going.